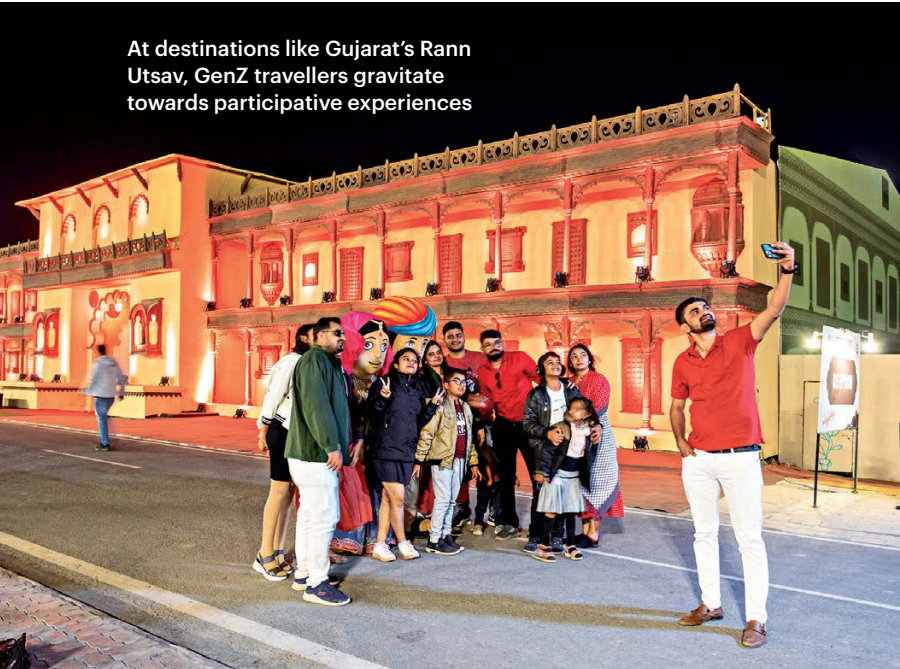


At destinations like Gujarat's Rann Utsav, GenZ travellers gravitate towards participative experiences



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ences. “What they object to is paying for something that feels redundant,” adds Thaker. “If the experience offers emotional or cultural value, price becomes secondary.”

Amrit Rajaratnam, Managing Director of Island Life Sri Lanka that operates four hotels across the emerald island, says, “Feeling connected to the destination is more important for Gen Z than traditional symbols of indulgence.”

What's on Their Plate

Across cities like Mumbai, Delhi, and Bengaluru, restaurateurs are noticing that younger diners are not simply eating out, they are curating social lives around food, choosing places that feel participatory and visually appealing online. “Sense of community is one thing Gen Z is extremely big on,” says food historian and author Anoothi Vishal. “They want to discover together, not compete through

price points.” That shift has helped propel regional pop-ups, micro-cuisines, and casual formats over rigid fine dining.

At Hunger Inc. Hospitality, the contrast is visible brand to brand. “Veronica’s sees a much higher Gen Z footfall,” says Co-founder Yash Bhanage, noting that alcohol-light, daytime-friendly concepts naturally attract younger diners.

Contrary to stereotypes of delivery-first habits, he observes that Gen Z enjoys being physically present. “From what we see at Veronica’s and Bombay Sweet Shop, they genuinely enjoy dine-in culture.” Yet this cohort is not being directly engineered for. Sameer Seth, Founder and CEO of Hunger Inc., insists that menu development still begins with instinct, not demographics.

“We are never saying, ‘This is what will appeal to Gen Z.’ We ask whether something is genuinely delicious,” he says, pointing to the Coffee Rasgulla Tiramisu. Its popularity among younger diners,

Seth argues, reflects resonance rather than targeting.

Discovery, however, has changed irrevocably. “Social media visibility now complements location. A strong digital presence can offset secondary locations, especially for Gen Z,” says Rajan Sethi, Managing Director of Bright Hospitality that owns brands such as Gurgaon-based OMO, Espres-sos Anyday, and Ikk Panjab. Over the past three to five years, Gen Z has grown from a peripheral audience to a core customer segment for Bright Hospitality.

Founder & CEO, Sahil Sambhi Brands that includes Japanico, Vietnam and Bawri, among others, Sahil Sambhi, goes further, arguing that aesthetics are inseparable from food. “Dining is becoming more specialised, experiential, and curated,” he says, noting how menu design, layouts, and tone are filtered instantly through Instagram.

Gen Z’s evolving relationship with alcohol is also reshaping menus. AD Singh of the Olive Group describes a move towards lower-intensity socialising. “They want quieter places, low ABV or zero-proof cocktails, and space for conversation,” he says.

Price, too, is more nuanced than assumed. “India has always been value-driven,” Bhanage notes, adding that younger consumers are simply earlier in their earning cycles. Bright Hospitality’s Sethi calls them “price-aware rather than price-sensitive,” willing to pay for ambience, beverages, and experiences that feel socially rewarding.

He adds that they are pushing the industry to be “more fluid, social, and experience-first.” The plate still matters. But so does everything around it. **BT**

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